United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

Intangible Cultural Heritage

A gender-responsive approach to safeguarding intangible cultural heritage

Unit 49 PowerPoint presentation

UNESCO
Intangible Cultural Heritage Section

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In this presentation …

This unit is divided into the following four sessions:

***Session 1**:* Introducing the gender dynamics of ICH and policy approaches

***Session 2**:* Taking a gender-responsive approach to safeguarding measures (Parts I and II)

***Session 3**:* Working with communities and groups in policy making and programming

***Session 4**:* Simulation of a fictitious National ICH Committee

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Applying a gender-responsive approach to ICH safeguarding

Question: How do we apply the theoretical approach of gender and ICH from Unit 48 in ICH safeguarding policies and measures?

Sources: Basic texts relating to

•Gender mainstreaming in UNESCO's cultural sector

•Introducing gender into the Operational Directives and other key documents of the Convention

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Revising the Operational Directives

Two main texts are relevant for us to examine here:

Decision 8.COM 5c.1 at 11(b) adopted by the Intergovernmental Committee at its 8th session in 2013.

Paragraph 14 of the Draft Operational Directives on 'Safeguarding intangible cultural heritage and sustainable development at the national level' (Annex to the Document ITH/14/9.COM/13.b) adopted by the Intergovernmental Committee at its 9th session in 2014.

Gender responsiveness are increasingly demonstrated by State parties through periodic reports and nominations as well.

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Taking a gender-responsive approach to ICH safeguarding

Some areas of ICH safeguarding where gender can be a significant factor include:

- Identification and inventorying
- Research and documentation
- Supporting transmission
- Preparing nomination files for the RL

Note: *Involving communities and groups in designing and implementing safeguarding plans is addressed separately.*

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Identification/inventorying

Important issues to consider here include:

•The need to take account of the gender dynamics of ICH elements in the process of identification and inventorying

•The need to encourage a dialogue within communities on gender and ‘their’ ICH element(s)

•The contribution of gender-defined groups to ICH is sometimes ignored as not being ‘heritage’ to be valued and safeguarded

•Is the gender dimension of Parties in consultation with communities and bearers fully addressed?

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Research and documentation

The 2003 Convention emphasizes the active involvement of communities, groups and, in some cases, individuals in safeguarding activities (Article 15).

Experts, academics and other (including community-based investigators) active in researching ICH need to be aware of a possible gender bias in the design of their research

Differences in male and female roles vis-à-vis ICH is an important area for research, not well covered up until now.

Programmes for documenting ICH may misinterpret the nature of traditional gender roles and ignore the gender complementarities that exist there.

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Supporting ICH transmission

Transmission of ICH often relies on informal gender-based modes of transmission, frequently from father-to-son, mother-to-daughter and (male/female) master to (male/female) apprentice.

In cases where traditional modes of transmission are weak, it is worth considering whether gender-bound attitudes contribute to problems in transmission

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Supporting ICH transmission (2)

Some questions to ask when considering specific cases:

•What is the gender specificity of the element (if any) and its social significance?

•How have the gender-specific aspects come about and how, if at all, have they changed over time and why?

•How, and in what contexts, might gender-specific ICH transmission affect an element's viability?

•Would the element be better safeguarded if the transmission were opened up, thus increasing the number of people practising it?

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Nominating elements to the RL

The process of nominating and selecting ICH elements for international inscription on the RL has been criticized for lack of gender awareness.

Consider, for example, the selection criteria for the RL:

R.1 The element constitutes intangible cultural heritage as defined in Article 2 of the Convention
R.2 Inscription of the element will contribute to ensuring visibility and awareness of the significance of the intangible cultural heritage and to encouraging dialogue, thus reflecting cultural diversity worldwide and testifying to human creativity.
R.3 Safeguarding measures are eleborated that may protect and promote the element
R.4 The element has been nominated following the widest possible participation of the community, group or, if applicable, individuals concerned and with their free, prior and informed consent.
R.5 The element is included in an inventory of the intangible cultural heritage

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Community involvement in designing ICH safeguarding plans

Some possible scenarios where communities are involved in designing safeguarding action plans for ‘their’ ICH element:

•An urban cultural community

•An indigenous or tribal community with its own customary institutions and rules

•A rather traditional rural community

•A professional group based on specific gender roles (e.g. women pearl divers in Japan …)

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‘Communities, groups and … individuals’

Some important issues to consider here are:

•The likely gender balance within government bodies (including the gender distribution of senior management roles)

•How this may impact on perception of gender with regard to ICH

•The role of NGOs and CSOs in this process

•What specific strategies can ensure a truly gender-inclusive approach to designing and implementing safeguarding plans

Discussion point: The 2003 Convention makes several references to ‘communities, groups and … individuals’ as leading agents in ICH safeguarding, but no mention is made of gender-specific groups. Do you think this is sufficient to take account of the gender dynamics of ICH safeguarding?

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Revising the National Safeguarding Plan for Firoozestan

Firoozestan, a Party to the 2003 Convention since 2004, developed its National Safeguarding Plan for ICH in 2005. The plan has a 15-year horizon, with an evaluation conducted every 5 years.

The 2nd five-yearly evaluation is now under way and it is being revised to bring this policy document more in line with current thinking about implementing the 2003 Convention.

The National ICH Committee made up of the Minister for Culture, representatives of the National Ethnographic Museum, Regional Government bodies, Local Government Authorities, a leading university, representatives of NGOs, etc. is tasked with, among other things, making it more gender-responsive.

You are the National ICH Committee …

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